virtue of silence, of stillness, of becoming aware of the essence and nature of things. What emerged out of this blend was ‘Chan’, an Indian concept layered with a Chinese sensibility. And when Chan crossed over to Japan, it became Zen, enriched by another layer of refinement and spiritual content.

Both in China and Japan, Zen had a significant impact on art and culture. In China, it led to the popularity of monochrome painting, new styles of calligraphy and poetry. What distinguished these forms was their impressionistic expression as opposed to a faithful and meticulous representation of objects. There is a certain spontaneity and free spirit that seem to underlie these art forms. The subjects are often commonplace and ordinary but are suffused with the heightened perception which Zen brings. The Chinese Zen master, Ching Yuan of the Tang dynasty, encapsulates this perception in the following words:

> Before a man studies Zen, to him mountains are mountains, and waters are waters; after he gets an insight into the truth of Zen Buddhism through the instruction of a good master, mountains to him are not mountains and waters are not waters; but after this when he really attains to the abode of rest, mountains are once more mountains and waters are waters. [2]

These words reflect the importance of seeking the true nature of existence through delving deep within one’s own self. This, then, becomes the prism through which one comprehends the oneness of all existence.

India gave to China the revolutionary idea of seeking truth from within oneself. It was an idea that germinated in India and wound its way to China and Japan, gathering local colour, fragrance and sensibility. In this long journey through time and space, the Indian beginnings continue to shine through later, more local accretions.

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In addition to these doctrinal offshoots of Indian Buddhism, China also saw the development of local cults associated with Buddhist deities, which became popular among the laity. The popularity of the Bodhisattva